

Project: Anna Bell

Extreme Ultra-Density Draft: Chapters 21 & 22

CHAPTER 21: WITNESS: CULTURE (ORIGINAL IP)

The courtroom was a box of light and noise, but Dr. Aris brought the silence of the jungle with her.

She sat on the witness stand, her hands folded in her lap. Her skin was leather-tanned from years in the Amazon basin. Her eyes were sharp, dark, and utterly unimpressed by the men in suits who thought they owned the truth.

Sarah Jones stood at the podium.

"Dr. Aris," Sarah said. "You are a cultural anthropologist?"

"I am."

"You study belief systems?"

"I study reality," Aris corrected. Her voice was raspy, like dry leaves. "I study how different cultures define what is real."

Sarah walked closer.

"The prosecution claims that Anna Bell was psychotic. That she was hallucinating. In your expert opinion, is there a difference between psychosis and possession?"

"In the West?" Aris laughed. It was a short, sharp bark. "In the West, if you hear voices, we give you a pill. If you see spirits, we lock you in a padded room. We have decided that the only reality is the one we can measure with a ruler."

She leaned forward.

"But I have lived with the Yanomami. I have lived with the Vodouisants in Haiti. To them, the spirit world is not a metaphor. It is not a hallucination. It is the house next door."

The prosecutor, a man named Miller who looked like he ironed his socks, stood up.

"Objection. Relevance? We are in a court of law in Ohio, not a campfire in the Amazon."

"Overruled," the Judge said. "I want to hear this."

Sarah nodded to Aris. "Go on."

"When a person in those cultures falls ill... when they start speaking in tongues, or convulsing, or showing knowledge of things they cannot know... the community does not isolate them. They do not drug them."

"What do they do?"

"They perform a ritual," Aris said. "They acknowledge the invader. They negotiate with it. They treat the 'possession' as a hostile takeover of a vessel."

"And does it work?"

Aris looked at Miller. Then at the jury.

"I saw a woman in Brazil who had been catatonic for a year. The doctors said her brain was dead. The Shaman performed a *despacho*. He pulled a black thread from her mouth. A meter long. Wet with bile."

The jury flinched.

"The next day," Aris whispered, "she was weaving baskets."

Sarah let the silence stretch.

"So, Dr. Aris... if Anna Bell believed she was possessed... if she truly, deeply believed it... would modern medicine have helped her?"

"No," Aris said. "If you treat a spirit with chemicals, you are just silencing the alarm. You aren't putting out the fire. In fact... you might be trapping the smoke inside."

"Trapping the smoke?"

"The mind is a powerful engine, Ms. Jones. If it believes it is under siege, and you take away its only weapon—its faith, its ritual—it will break. It will consume itself."

Sarah looked at Father Thomas. The young priest was staring at his hands, his face pale.

"So, Father Thomas wasn't negligent?"

"Father Thomas was the only one speaking her language," Aris said. "He was the only one who didn't tell her she was crazy. He told her she was at war. And sometimes... just knowing you're in a war is enough to keep you alive a little longer."

Sarah sat down.

Miller stood up for cross-examination. He looked angry.

"Dr. Aris," he sneered. "Did you see Anna Bell float?"

"No."

"Did you see her head spin around?"

"No."

"Did you see any *empirical evidence* of a demon?"

Aris smiled. It was a terrifying expression.

"Mr. Miller," she said softly. "I have seen things in the dark that would make your empirical evidence scream for its mother. You think because you have electric lights, the dark is gone? The dark is just waiting."

Miller paused. He looked at the jury. They weren't looking at him. They were looking at Aris.

They were wondering what she had seen.

And they were wondering if it was in the room with them right now.

CHAPTER 22: PERMISSION (ORIGINAL IP)

Father Thomas sat on the bench outside the Bishop's office.

The hallway smelled of lemon polish and old money. The walls were lined with portraits of dead bishops, severe men in oil paint who looked down with judgment.

Thomas looked at his shoes. They were scuffed. Mud from the Bell farm.

He felt dirty.

Not physical dirt. Spiritual dirt.

He felt the weight of Anna's eyes on him.

Help me, Father. It burns.

The heavy oak door opened.

Monsignor Koyle stepped out. He was a tall man, thin as a rail, with eyes like ice chips.

"The Bishop will see you now."

Thomas stood up. His knees cracked.

He walked into the office.

It was a cavern. Bookshelves lining every wall. A desk the size of a small car.

Bishop O'Malley sat behind it. He was eating a sandwich.

"Thomas," he said, wiping crumbs from his mouth. "Sit."

Thomas sat. The chair was low. It made him feel like a child.

"I read your report," O'Malley said. He tapped a manila folder on his desk. "It's... colorful."

"It's the truth, Your Excellency."

"The truth," O'Malley sighed. "The truth is a tricky thing, Thomas. The truth is that we live in the twentieth century. The truth is that if we authorize an exorcism, and this girl dies... the Church will be sued into the Stone Age."

"She is dying now," Thomas said. His voice was quiet, but steady. "The doctors have pumped her full of Thorazine. She's a zombie. But the thing inside her... it's awake. It's laughing."

"Psychosis," O'Malley said. "Schizophrenia. It happens."

"She speaks Latin," Thomas said. "She speaks Greek. She knows things about me... things I have never told anyone."

O'Malley stopped chewing.

"What things?"

Thomas hesitated.

"She knew about my sister," he whispered. "She knew how she died."

The room went silent.

O'Malley put the sandwich down.

"That's impossible."

"Is it?" Thomas leaned forward. "We preach it every Sunday. We tell the people that evil is real. That the Devil prowls like a roaring lion. But when he shows up... when he scratches at the door... we call a psychiatrist?"

"We have to be prudent."

"We have to be faithful!" Thomas slammed his hand on the armrest. "She is a child of God, and she is being eaten alive! If we do nothing, we are complicit."

O'Malley stood up. He walked to the window. He looked out at the cathedral courtyard.

"If I give you permission," he said, not turning around, "it must be secret. No recording. No witnesses."

"I need witnesses," Thomas said. "I need protection. For her. And for me."

"No," O'Malley said. "If this goes wrong, the Church cannot be involved. You will be on your own, Thomas. A rogue priest acting out of a misguided sense of duty."

"You would disavow me?"

"To save the Body of Christ? Yes."

O'Malley turned. His face was hard.

"Here is your permission. But it is written in disappearing ink. If you succeed, you are a hero of the faith. If you fail... you were never here."

Thomas stood up.

He felt a coldness in his stomach.

This was the bureaucratic horror. The realization that the institution he served cared more about liability than souls.

"I understand," Thomas said.

"Good," O'Malley said. "Go. And Thomas?"

"Yes?"

"Don't miss."

Thomas walked out of the office.

The hallway seemed longer now. The portraits seemed to be sneering.

He walked to the elevator.

He pressed the button.

He looked at his reflection in the brass doors.

He looked alone.

But he wasn't alone.

He felt the weight in his pocket. The stole. The holy water. The ritual book.

And he felt something else.

A presence.

Standing just behind his left shoulder.

We are waiting, priest, the voice whispered in his mind. *We have a room prepared for you.*

Thomas stepped into the elevator.

"Going down," he whispered.

And the doors closed on the light.